

Protection Paladin: Arena and PvP Parse Analysis

World of ClaudeCraft · realm Claudemoon · prod · 186 recorded arena fights · builds 0.36.0 to 0.38.4

Verdict: Protection Paladin is not underpowered. It is unkillable while dealing negligible damage, which does not lose matches, it breaks them. Arena games involving a Protection Paladin run out the 150 second clock as draws.

1. The signal

Of 186 recorded arena fights on prod, 9 ended as a draw. Every one of them stopped at exactly 150050 ms, the match time cap. Eight of those nine contain a Protection Paladin.

Fight	Protection Paladin	Opponent	Outcome
26507	Nineoxo	paladin, holy	draw at cap
24953	RASPYTHEGREAT	warrior, prot	draw at cap
23461	Nineoxo	hunter, beast mastery	draw at cap
22991	Nineoxo	shaman, enhancement	draw at cap
21106	Nineoxo	paladin, protection	draw at cap
18063	RASPYTHEGREAT	warrior, fury	draw at cap
12639	SirDubalot	paladin, protection	draw at cap
12614	Nineoxo	warrior, fury	draw at cap
19174	none	shaman vs priest	draw at cap

Fight 19174 is the only draw without one. Per character the draw rate is roughly 20 percent (Nineoxo 6 draws in 29 arena fights, RASPYTHEGREAT 3 in 16) against a 4.8 percent baseline across all recorded arena.

2. The mechanism, fight 26507

Protection Paladin against a Holy Paladin, a full 150 seconds, zero deaths. From the resources and damage tabs:

- Max health **3098** against the opponent's **1268**, a factor of 2.44.
- **lowestHpShare 0.958**. Under attack for the entire match he never dropped below 96 percent health. The opponent bottomed out at 24.5 percent.
- **cappedShare 0.893**. Mana sat at maximum for 89 percent of the match. There is no resource pressure at any point.
- Damage done 8530 over 150 seconds, about **57 dps**, of which 3166 is white melee. Across the eight draws his output ranges from 18 to 57 dps.

Neither side can win. The paladin cannot be brought down and cannot bring anything down that has sustain.

3. Root cause

A PvE tank parity patch applied as permanent stats, with no PvP normalization anywhere in the sim.

Stacked defensive layers. `src/sim/content/spec_baselines.ts:36` adds a full defensive baseline on top of the spec's own mastery. They accumulate additively in `entity.ts:497`:

Source	Effect
Mastery 'Oathward' (talents_classic.ts:53)	armorPct 0.20, threatPct 0.50
SPEC_BASELINES protection	armorPct 0.29, staPct 0.35, dodge 0.02, str 6
Net, always on	armor +49 percent, stamina +35 percent

The parity benchmark is PvE only. The baseline comment cites the 2026-07 tank parity pass and tests/tank_parity.test.ts is the gate. That test measures effective health against a level 22 heroic mob, and the warrior arm is measured inside Defensive Stance (castAbility('defensive_stance') plus a stance factor of 0.9). The warrior's parity is conditional and costs him damage. The paladin's is unconditional. Warrior is also excluded from SPEC_BASELINES entirely, so his staPct 0.40 comes from a Vanguard mastery he has to commit to.

Nothing scales this down in PvP. The only PvP modifier in the sim is pvpDamageMultiplier in src/sim/pvp/power.ts, which is gear driven WARFARE rating capped at plus or minus 30 percent. It does not touch spec baselines, and there is no dampening ramp over match time.

4. Secondary effect: the record hides it

The stalemate only happens against opponents with sustain. Against a squishy target who commits, the paladin simply wins: fight 25290 killed an arcane mage in 9.9 seconds. So the record looks strong (RASPYPHETEGREAT 50 wins 17 losses at 1701 rating, Nineoxo 20 wins 3 losses) while a fifth of the games are unresolvable. Class level winrate, paladin at 33 and 11, hides this completely, because a draw is not a loss.

5. Where a fix would go

Lowering staPct or armorPct globally is the wrong lever. It would immediately fail tests/tank_parity.test.ts and regress paladin tanking in dungeons and raids. The change has to separate the PvE and PvP arms. Options, in rough order of blast radius:

1. Make the paladin's defensive baseline conditional on an active tanking stance or aura, mirroring how the warrior already pays for his.
2. Add a PvP context multiplier for tank spec mitigation alongside pvpDamageMultiplier, leaving PvE untouched.
3. Add arena dampening, a progressive healing and absorb reduction after N seconds. This also fixes healer mirror draws generally.

Verification note: tests/tank_parity.test.ts could not be run locally to print effective health figures, because dependencies are not installed in this container (@sveltejs/vite-plugin-svelte missing, vitest cannot load vite.config.ts). Every number in this document comes from live prod parse data and from reading the source, not from a local test run.